

ALLIES AND OPPOSITION LE

India has become a checker-board of parties across its political spectrum. In the UPA's second term, it has gained support from foes-turned-friends even as a few allies turn hostile. It is educative to see the range of views on the Government's performance.



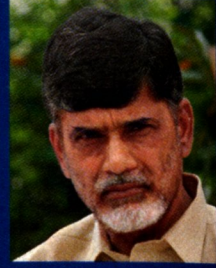
Nitin Gadkari
President
BJP



Sitaram Vechury
Member
CPM Politburo



Lalu Prasad
President
RJD



Chandrababu Naidu
President
TDP

How would you rate the UPA II on a scale of 0 to 10?

2/10

Declined to grade

"Too early to give marks."

3.5/10

How would you assess the UPA's second term?

From reducing poverty to controlling terrorism, it is a failure on all fronts. Emboldened by its windfall electoral success, it is using government machinery to continue in power. CBI is an example and so is their joining hands with the anti-women's reservation lobby.

This is the first coalition Government in two decades where a ruling party came to power with over 200 seats. Despite this, in the first year itself, the Government was forced to count their numbers. While the first UPA had the CMP, UPA II is without any sense of direction.

Performance is okay. Seems to be carrying forward the good policies framed during the UPA I regime. However, they are doing nothing extraordinary. The Sachar Committee report or the Ranganath Mishra Commission recommendations are yet to be implemented.

A great disappointment and a total failure. In its first year itself, it is marked by scandal and corruption. It is unable to perform because it is held to ransom and has begun to play around with independent investigative agencies like the CBI.

Can you list three areas they have succeeded in?

Continuing in power is one. Managing contradictions is another. No clear policy on relations with Pakistan.

Partially successful on Women's Reservation Bill and right to education. Success in keeping Pakistan talks alive.

They seem to be trying a few things in many areas. One is education. There are many initiatives but implementation lags.

It has succeeded in spreading corruption, encouraging unscrupulous elements and is in the doldrums.

The three important areas they have failed in.

Controlling prices. Failure in dealing effectively with the Naxals. Have not adhered to the principles of probity and transparency—mainly to shield scams and corrupt ministers.

Despite loud claims about economic recovery, food prices are on an upward spiral. On the foreign policy front, it still remains a junior partner of the US. Government is keen on IPL not on BPL.

Price rise, unemployment and extremism are some of the main fronts where the Government can do more.

Inflation, fudging figures and siphoning funds from NREGA. There is rank corruption in several ministries besides aborting the reform process.

Will it last the full term?

Masters of the *jugaad* technology, I wonder how long it will really help them.

The real threat comes from within. Its longevity depends on how it manages the threat.

Most certainly, yes. We all want it to complete its term.

With the help of manipulators and blackmailers it can survive.